back him as he is seen as the best bet to win against the BJP. In rearranging the landscape thus, he has made the 2022 election a bipolar contest between the SP and the BJP rather than a multi-cornered fight involving the BSP and Congress as well. If he can reach the 40 per cent mark in terms of total votes, it could lead him to victory. In 2017, the BJP's landslide win came by virtue of a cumulative vote share of 39.67 per cent. Akhilesh's strategy is to chip away methodically at that and stack up his own Lego blocks high enough to bring power within reach.



ANI

THE BJP JUGGERNAUT, however, is not sitting idle and watching Akhilesh puncture its wheels. The Empire struck right back with a series of moves designed to stop him in his tracks. They exposed the fragile unity of the Yadav parivar by winning over Aparna, wife of Akhilesh's stepbrother Pratik Yadav, allowing Keshav Prasad Maurya, the state's deputy chief minister, to comment, "If he can't keep his parivar together, how can he run this large state unitedly?" They also sealed their alliances with a dominant faction of the Apna Dal, representing the Kurmi community, who form the second largest chunk of OBC votes after the Yadavs, and the Nishad Party, which commands a sizeable following among the EBC fisherfolk community in the riverine belts of the east. Anupriya Patel, Union minister and Apna Dal (S) president, says: "The SP was late in wooing the non-Yadav OBCs. We are in tune with the BJP, having contested together in earlier elections." The BJP then dented the Congress by luring R.P.N. Singh, a former confidant of the Gandhis, now repackaged as an OBC face. Shah also called a meeting of prominent Jats in an urgent bid to assuage the community and weaken the SP-RLD alliance.

The BJP has multiple other stratagems to fall back on. Its trump card remains Modi and the idea of the "double-engine sarkar", referring to the virtuous synergy that comes about by having the same party ruling both the Centre and the state. To counter the economic devastation caused by the pandemic, even if belatedly, the state government supplemented central sops with its own free food rations for the poor. Also, Adityanath claims he has vigorously implemented the various central schemes relating to housing and sanitation for the poor, besides free gas connections and loan waivers for farmers. Says Badri Narayan, a social historian and professor at the G.B. Pant Social Science Institute in Prayagraj, "The *labharthi*s (beneficiaries) have become an important vote bank for the BJP as they have reached out to the poorest of the poor through their schemes." On the development front, Adityanath talks of the massive infrastructure his government is building, including six new expressways and nine airports, and catalysing industrial growth by attracting investment worth over Rs 4 lakh crore, with many of the projects into production already. He says the unemployment rate has dropped to 5 per cent annually while it once averaged 14 to 16 per cent.

IF THE CASTE COMBINATIONS AKHILESH HAS PUT TOGETHER START SHOWING RESULTS, THE BJP IS LIKELY TO GO HEAVIER ON POLARISATION TO CONSOLIDATE THE HINDU VOTE

While such claims are difficult to verify, particularly after the pandemic, central government statistics show that while per capita GDP at current prices increased by an average of 7.8 per cent annually in the final three years of Akhilesh's rule, the growth slowed to 5.2 per cent during the first three years of Adityanath's tenure, even before Covid struck. (UP's per capita income of Rs 73,792 is well below the all-India average of Rs